Synthesis and the diagnostic memo

How do we turn a body of evidence into an argument a decision-maker can use?



Today

By the end of today, you will have

Written a two-page diagnostic memo with a governing message, and submitted Gate 3.

- Distinguish findings from insights.
- Structure an argument top-down with the Pyramid Principle.
- Open with Situation, Complication, Question and Answer.
- Keep facts, inferences and assumptions visibly separate in the memo.

Competencies: I1 · F4 · J3

Session plan

10 min	**Opening problem**
15 min	**Concept: answer first**
15 min	**Demonstration: Madhyapur pyramid**
20 min	**Activity: governing message race**
40 min	**Gate 3: pod peer review**
20 min	**Debrief and planning**

Opening problem

- **The Commissioner has four minutes before a meeting. What is the one sentence about Madhyapur's waste problem they must read?**

Write it. Then compare it with the first sentence of the last thing you wrote.

Findings are not insights

Findings

- Separation rose in planned colonies, not in informal settlements
- Crews in two cities changed practice when payment terms changed
- Fines without monitoring raised dumping

Insight

- Madhyapur's separation problem is mainly a collection-contract problem, not an awareness problem: households respond to what crews do, and crews respond to what they are paid for.

An insight says what the findings mean together, for the decision.

The Pyramid Principle: answer first, then support

Separation fails mainly at collection, because the contract pays for weight. Campaigns alone will not fix it.

Households respond to what crews do

- Separation barely rose where only bins were given
- Residents report seeing separated bags mixed

Crews respond to what they are paid for

- Practice changed where payment terms changed
- Fines without monitoring raised dumping

Downstream capacity decides whether separation is worthwhile

- No dry-waste facility in the city plan
- Waste pickers recover dry waste informally

SCQA: the opening of the Madhyapur memo

Element	Madhyapur
Situation	The 2016 rules require households to separate waste. Madhyapur collects door to door through a contractor.
Complication	Most households still hand over mixed waste, the landfill is nearly full, and campaigns have not changed this.
Question	Why does separation fail, and what should the Commissioner decide next year?
Answer	It fails mainly at collection, because the contract pays for weight. What the contract pays for is the decision to make.

Writing the memo: five rules

1. **Answer first**

   The governing message is the first sentence, not the last.

2. **One idea per paragraph**

   Each paragraph supports one key line of the pyramid.

3. **Match words to evidence**

   Use shows, suggests or we assume, in line with your Ledger.

4. **Numbers with sources**

   Every figure carries a year and a source, rounded honestly.

5. **End with the decision**

   Close with what the decision-maker must now decide, and what remains uncertain.

A thinker for your case

Richard Rumelt

Good Strategy/Bad Strategy, 2011

Rumelt argued that the kernel of good strategy is a diagnosis that names the critical challenge, a guiding policy for dealing with it, and coherent actions that carry the policy out.

The question it puts to your case

Does your argument contain a diagnosis, a guiding policy and coherent action, or is it a list of goals?

Answer it in one sentence in your workbook today.

Activity: The governing message race

Reduce a body of evidence to one defensible governing message and three key lines.

Scenario

Each pod gets the same short evidence dossier on a common case: low take-up of a maternity benefit scheme in a stylised district, with six findings of mixed strength. In fifteen minutes, write the governing message and three key lines, then compare across pods.

What to do

1. Read the six findings and tag each as fact, inference or assumption.
2. Group them into three key lines that do not overlap.
3. Write the governing message the three key lines support.
4. Check: does any key line rest on an assumption alone?
5. Post your pyramid and compare it with the other pods'.

Time 20 minutes

Groups Pods of four

Output A governing message and three key lines

Gate 3 pod peer review: 40 minutes

1

Swap

Each member reviews another member's memo and testing matrix.

2

Check

Use the Gate 3 rubric: evidence, testing and the memo.

3

Write

One strength, one critical weakness, one required revision.

4

Discuss

Eight minutes per case, led by the chair.

5

Revise

Make at least one change before you submit tonight.

Reviewers: read only the first paragraph first. Can you state the answer and the decision from it alone?

Your case: Worksheet 6.2

Diagnostic memo

1. Write your governing message in one sentence.
2. Build the pyramid: three key lines and their evidence.
3. Draft the SCQA opening.
4. Write the memo in two pages or fewer, answer first, ending with the decision to be made.
5. Submit Gate 3 with a revision note and AI disclosure.

Hand in

Gate 3 (Worksheets 5.1 to 5.3 and 6.1, revised, and the memo) by the end of Day 15. Feedback returned by Day 17.

Quality check

The governing message comes first.

Tag every claim in your Analyst's Ledger: fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.

What to take away

1. An insight says what the findings mean together, for the decision.
2. Put the answer first, then support it with three key lines that do not overlap.
3. SCQA gets a busy reader to the question and the answer fast.
4. Match every verb to the strength of the evidence.

Exit task Read your governing message to a neighbour. Write down their first question.

Before the next session

Independent work

Rest. If you have time, read your memo aloud and cut every sentence the decision-maker would skip. About 30 minutes.

Read

Minto, The Pyramid Principle, the chapters on the pyramid structure and on introductions (edition to confirm).

Next

Day 16: Generating options

Week 4 begins: generating options without jumping to the first attractive idea.